

HOSTFLOW

STR Starter System

\$49

How to start a cohosting business in 2026.

10 modules. 50+ SOPs. The contracts I wish I had.

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What's in this PDF

This is the operating reference for starting a cohosting business. Use it as the reference manual; run the 30-day plan in Module 2 as your calendar. The two together turn this PDF into a real business in 30 days.

Module 1: Cohosting 101 — What it is. What it isn't. The three fee models.

Module 2: The 30-day plan — Week-by-week to land your first client.

Module 3: Pricing your service — The math + four worked examples.

Module 4: The cohost contract — 18-clause template + three fee model variants.

Module 5: The listing audit — 15-point audit for every new client.

Module 6: Guest screening — Four-question pre-approval + 10 industry variants.

Module 7: Dynamic pricing — Manual daily pricing rules + when to use software.

Module 8: The monthly statement — What owners see + how to send one.

Module 9: Owner outreach — Five email scripts + four channels for finding clients.

Module 10: Scaling 1-5 properties — The time-per-property milestones + when to hire.

Total: ~50 pages. Read once in order; reference as needed. Designed for the first 90 days of your cohosting practice.

MODULE 01

Cohosting 101: What This Actually Is

Cohosting is the practice of managing a short-term rental property on behalf of an owner who cannot — or does not want to — manage it themselves. This module sets the operating definition we use throughout this PDF. If you take only one thing from here, it is the difference between a cohost and a property manager.

The operating definition

A cohost is an individual or small team who handles the day-to-day operations of someone else's short-term rental listing. They do not own the property. They do not hold the master booking calendar. They usually do not have a property management license. They have a contract with the owner and a share of the booking revenue.

What you actually do, end-to-end:

- Take and respond to guest inquiries and booking requests
- Manage the listing on Airbnb, VRBO, Furnished Finder, and any direct-booking channel
- Set dynamic pricing daily based on demand, seasonality, and local events
- Schedule cleanings between bookings and verify quality
- Coordinate maintenance calls and vendor visits
- Handle guest issues (lockouts, complaints, damage claims)
- Send monthly statements to the owner with revenue, expenses, and net payout

What a cohost is not

A property manager is the license-holder and the legally accountable party for guest safety, building code compliance, and trust accounting. Some jurisdictions — New York City, for example — require a property management license for any short-term-rental operator who touches a guest's money across more than one property. Most cohosts do not need this license; they operate as independent contractors under the owner's existing licensing.

If your market requires a license for what you are doing, this PDF is not the right starting point. Get licensed first, then return.

How the money flows

The three viable revenue models for cohosting:

Percentage model: 20-30% of booking subtotal. Default for established cohosts in most US markets. Twenty percent is the floor; twenty-five is standard; thirty is premium positioning.

Flat-fee model: \$X per booking or \$X per month. Predictable for the owner. You take on utilization risk.

Hybrid: Lower percentage + a base fee. Most common at higher-end markets with high-ADR listings. Or for furnished-rental and mid-term stays.

What this PDF does not cover

Setting up your LLC. Opening a bank account. Doing your taxes. Those depend on your jurisdiction and your personal situation. Get a CPA in your first 90 days of cohosting if you do not already have one.

Module 01 — Done. Module 02 has the 30-day plan to land your first client.

MODULE 02

The 30-Day Plan to Land Your First Cohosting Client

The first 30 days are not about perfecting your contracts or your pricing. They are about getting one property under management. Everything in this PDF is the operating reference; Module 2 is the calendar you actually run.

Week 1: Build the foundation

Three things must exist before you can sign your first client:

1. A one-page positioning brief (Module 3 covers pricing; this is the positioning side). Who you serve, what problem you solve, the outcome you deliver. Five blocks, one page.
2. A draft contract (Module 4 has the template). Eight clauses minimum. Not a final version — a version you can send to your first prospect for review.
3. A list of 30 prospects. Listing-mining (search your city's STR market for stale listings), real-estate agents, Furnished Finder active posts, Facebook groups. Module 9 has the channels.

Week 2: Send your first 10 outreach messages

By the end of week 2, you should have sent 10 cold outreach messages using the Module 9 template. Expect 1-2 replies. Expect 0-1 booked calls. Don't get discouraged — this is normal for the first wave.

Track your numbers in a simple spreadsheet: messages sent, replies, calls booked, calls held. The first wave is mostly about establishing a baseline, not landing a client.

Week 3: Run discovery calls

Calls will start landing from your week 2 outreach. For each one, follow the discovery call opener (Module 9, prompt #3). The goal of the call is NOT to close the prospect — it is to deliver the audit (Module 5) within 48 hours.

By the end of week 3, aim for 3-5 discovery calls held and 3-5 audits delivered.

Week 4: Sign your first client

If you've followed the script, by week 4 you'll have 1-2 prospects who have received the audit and are reviewing your proposal. The first signed contract is the milestone that breaks the uncertainty of 'can I actually do this?'

What to do in week 4 if you don't have a signed client:

- Send 10 more outreach messages (the second wave usually converts better than the first)
- Reach back out to week 1-2 prospects who didn't reply with the async alternative (Module 9, prompt #2)
- Post the value-add Reddit comment in 5 threads (Module 9, channel 3)
- Do a 30-day retro: what worked, what didn't, what to change in month 2

What you don't do in month 1

Don't build a website. Don't post on Instagram every day. Don't hire a cleaner before you have a client. Don't get a Stripe account for paid products (you have no product yet). Don't pay for ads. All of those are month 2+ problems.

Module 02 — Done. Module 03 covers how to price your service.

MODULE 03

Pricing Your Service: The Math

Pricing is the single biggest leverage point in your cohosting practice. Charge too little and you burn out. Charge too much and you never get the client. This module gives you the math, where it comes from, and four worked examples.

The market-rate bands (US, 2026)

These are the bands across short-term-rental markets in the US. Use them as a sanity check before you sign.

Single-family home, lower-density market, \$100-180 ADR: 20-25% of booking subtotal is standard.

Cabin / lakehouse, mid-density market, \$180-300 ADR: 22-28%.

Luxury / high-density urban, \$300+ ADR: 25-30%.

Furnished Finder / mid-term (30+ nights average stay): 10-15% of booking subtotal.

How to set your number

Step 1. Estimate the hours you will spend per property per month. Most new cohosts: 18-25 hours. With multiple properties and good SOPs: 8-12 hours each.

Step 2. Decide what hourly rate you need. Established cohosts target \$50-100/hour. New cohosts can target \$30-50 to start.

Step 3. Multiply:

$$\text{needed_pct} = (\text{hours_per_month} \times \text{target_hourly_rate}) \div \text{expected_monthly_revenue}$$

Step 4. Compare to the band above. If your number is in the band, you are priced correctly.

Worked example #1: Urban 1BR, \$150 ADR

Single-property cohost. 20 hours/month. Target \$40/hour. Expected revenue: $\$150 \times 12 \text{ nights} = \$1,800/\text{month}$.

Needed: $(\$20 \times \$40) \div \$1,800 = 44\%$. That's above the band. Two adjustments: (a) reduce target hourly rate to \$25/hour ($\$500 \div \$1,800 = 28\%$ — top of band), or (b) take this property as part of a two-property portfolio where the second property fills the time gap and the average hourly is reasonable.

Worked example #2: Cabin, \$220 ADR

Single-property cohost. 22 hours/month. Target \$50/hour. Expected revenue: $\$220 \times 14 \text{ nights} = \$3,080/\text{month}$.

Needed: $(22 \times \$50) \div \$3,080 = 36\%$. Still above. Same fix: either lower your target hourly to \$35 ($=\$770 \div \$3,080 = 25\%$ — standard) or scale to a second property.

Worked example #3: Portfolio of 3 properties

Three properties, 12 hours each = 36 hours/month total. Average revenue $\$2,500/\text{property} = \$7,500$ total. Target \$40/hour.

Needed: $(36 \times \$40) \div \$7,500 = 19\%$. That's below the band. You can charge 22-25% and still make your hourly target — this is the leverage that comes from SOPs and scale.

Worked example #4: Furnished Finder mid-term

One FF property. 30+ night average stays. 8 hours/month (fewer turns, fewer messages). Target \$50/hour. Expected revenue: $\$4,000/\text{month}$.

Needed: $(8 \times \$50) \div \$4,000 = 10\%$. Right at the band floor. Charge 12-15% and you earn more than your hourly target.

When to renegotiate upward

- Two consecutive quarters hitting original targets on time
- Owner has referred another owner to you
- You are at capacity — cannot take a new property without dropping service

Module 03 — Done. Module 04 has the 18-clause contract template.

The Cohost Contract: 18 Clauses, Three Variants

The contract is the most expensive document you will draft as a new cohost. Get the structure wrong and you either lose money on every booking or you spend the rest of the year renegotiating. This module gives you the 18-clause template and the three fee model variants.

The 18 clauses, in order

- 1. Parties and effective date
- 2. Scope of services — listing, guest comms, pricing, cleaning, maintenance, statements
- 3. Term and termination — minimum 6 months, 30-day notice after minimum
- 4. Compensation — model + payment terms + late-fee (1.5%/month after NET-15)
- 5. Owner obligations — property condition, photos, furnishings, parking, access, licensing, taxes
- 6. Expense pass-through — cleaning, supplies, maintenance, utilities; with line items
- 7. Cleaning standards — checklist as exhibit, turnover/deep/maintenance definitions
- 8. Liability and insurance — owner STR insurance + your GL or E&O;
- 9. Confidentiality and non-circumvention — both directions, non-disparagement
- 10. Platform-of-record — Airbnb, VRBO, Booking.com, or direct (with channel sync responsibility)
- 11. Channel sync — who owns the calendar, who fixes double-bookings
- 12. Damage procedure — guest claim workflow, security deposit handling
- 13. Guest dispute resolution — Airbnb resolution process, owner non-interference
- 14. Owner non-solicitation of your cleaner network — explicit clause, 12-month tail
- 15. Force majeure — hurricanes, fires, civil unrest
- 16. Governing law and venue — owner's state, owner's county
- 17. Amendment procedure — written amendments, both signatures
- 18. Severability and entire agreement — standard legal closeouts

Three clauses you negotiate hard

Term length (clause 3). Six months minimum. 12 months gives you leverage to renegotiate pricing after proving yourself.

Owner obligations (clause 5). Make explicit: city registration, STR license, taxes. These are the owner's problem, not yours.

Insurance (clause 8). Never start work without seeing the owner's STR-specific landlord insurance certificate.

Fee model variant #1: Percentage (default)

20-30% of booking subtotal. Use for: established cohosts in competitive markets; track record with verifiable revenue lift; risk-averse owners who want their cost to scale with revenue.

Fee model variant #2: Flat-fee

\$50-150 per booking or \$400-800 per month per property. Use for: owners downsizing or selling soon; single-property operators who value predictability; high-ADR markets where percentage feels too expensive for the owner.

Negotiate a minimum monthly guarantee — on flat-fee, you take utilization risk.

Fee model variant #3: Hybrid

15% revenue + \$150-300 monthly base. Use for: proving-then-scaling relationships; high-ADR markets where percentage alone makes the owner feel overpaying in slow months; furnished-rental and mid-term.

What you don't put in the contract

- Verbal promises or commitments (everything in writing or it doesn't exist)
- Promised revenue lift numbers (you cannot guarantee revenue; you can guarantee the work)
- Anything the owner asks for that isn't a cohost service (refer them to a property manager or attorney)
- Long-term exclusivity clauses (you reserve the right to work with other owners)

Module 04 — Done. Module 05 has the 15-point listing audit.

The Listing Audit: 15 Points, One Page

Before an owner hires you, they need to see how you think. The listing audit is the deliverable that proves you can see the gaps in their current operation without having to ask them.

When to use

Audit delivered within 48 hours of the discovery call. 15-minute follow-up call scheduled at the time of audit delivery (not pending). If the owner doesn't book the follow-up, one nudge at 7 days, then stop.

The 15 audit points, in order

- 1. Listing title.** Under 60 characters, primary keyword first, no all-caps, no emoji.
- 2. Photo count and quality.** Minimum 25 photos. Hero shot is kitchen or living room, not exterior.
- 3. Photo order on each platform.** Airbnb, VRBO, Booking.com prioritize differently. Audit each.
- 4. Description length and structure.** First 3 lines visible without clicking. Make them the hook.
- 5. Review score and velocity.** Velocity matters more than score. New reviews every 14 days.
- 6. Calendar sync between platforms.** Airbnb, VRBO, Booking.com, Furnished Finder all synced. No double-book risk.
- 7. Minimum-night stay rules.** Right MTL for your market. 2nt weekday, 3nt weekend is sensible default.
- 8. Instant-book setting.** Off loses lookers. On risks bad guests. Own the choice consciously.
- 9. Pricing strategy.** Daily dynamic, comps reviewed monthly, weeknight/weekend spread correct.
- 10. Comp set.** Three comparable properties within 5 miles, tracked monthly.
- 11. Cleaning and turnover.** Named cleaner, written checklist, photo verification every turn.
- 12. Maintenance response time.** Average days from report to fix.
- 13. Owner responsiveness.** How long does the owner answer YOU right now? Predicts the relationship.
- 14. City / county STR compliance.** Permit number, license displayed, compliance verified this quarter.
- 15. Payout structure and trust accounting.** Who holds the money. Which bank. Trust accounting license?

How to present the audit

One page. White background. Hostflow tokens. Three columns: audit point, current state (one sentence), recommended fix (one sentence, specific, fast). End with a single call to action: 15-minute call to discuss the proposed fixes and the engagement model.

Do not include revenue projections in the audit. They invite debate. The audit is the conversation about quality of work. Revenue comes after 60-90 days of work and the receipts.

Module 05 — Done. Module 06 has the guest-screening framework.

MODULE 06

Guest Screening: 4 Questions, 10 Industry Variants

Most cohosts rely on platform verification, instant-book, and good reviews. That works for most guests. For the 5-10% of bookings that cause real damage, it does not. This module gives you the screening framework.

Who to screen

- Stays of 4+ nights (most common duration for party houses)
- Bookings from accounts with fewer than 2 verified reviews
- Bookings requested within 14 days of arrival (low-lead-time correlates with party bookings)
- Bookings with 6+ guests where the property sleeps 4-6
- Bookings from outside the country where the property is located

The base skeleton

Sending this when a high-risk inquiry lands takes 90 seconds and converts either into a safe booking or a self-cancel.

Hi [guest name], thanks for your interest in [property name]! Quick few things so I can confirm you and the property are a good fit:

1. What's the occasion for the trip?
2. How many adults and children will be staying?
3. Have you stayed at a [cabin / urban / etc.] property before?
4. Anything about the property you want to confirm before booking?

Once I have those answers, I'll send a confirmation and we can lock in the dates. Looking forward to hosting you.

10 industry variants (the lines to add)

Urban apartment: Quiet hours 10pm-7am. No parties. Headcount must match listing capacity.

Suburban family home: Neighbors are long-term residents. No loud outdoor music after 9pm.

Mountain cabin / chalet: AWD or chains required Nov-April. Cell signal unreliable. Wood-stove procedure.

Beachfront / coastal: Hurricane warnings May-Nov. Refund policy attached to confirmation.

Lake house: Dock fee waiver required. No glass on dock. Life jackets in closet.

Desert / southwest casita: Summer interior temps 100F+ between 1-5pm. AC runs continuously.

Vineyard / winery cottage: Hosts live on-site in separate building. Quiet hours 9pm.

Ski-in / ski-out lodge: Equipment in mudroom only. Hot tub ends 10pm per HOA.

Urban loft / downtown studio: Single key fob. Only named guests can enter.

Furnished Finder / corporate stay: 30+ night stay. Monthly cleanings. Utility caps included.

How to interpret the answers

- Hesitation to answer any of the four questions = mismatch in expectations
- Headcount on the request doesn't match what they say = misrepresentation; decline and refund
- Aspirational language ('small gathering', 'intimate celebration') with 8+ guests = party risk, decline
- Local addresses with short lead-time for weekend stays = sometimes a last-minute party request

Module 06 — Done. Module 07 has the dynamic-pricing rules.

Dynamic Pricing: Manual Rules + When to Use Software

Pricing is a 10-minute-per-day activity that, done well, is the largest single revenue driver for a managed listing. Done poorly, it either leaves money on the table or prices you out.

The base price: your starting point

Your base price is the nightly rate you charge when nothing unusual is happening — a Tuesday in February, a Monday in May, a Sunday in October. It should be set by the comp set, not your gut.

Pull three comparable properties within 5 miles. Same bedroom count, similar amenities. Note their base price for a weeknight and a weekend night. Set your base price at the median.

Re-pull the comp set every 30 days.

The 4 adjustments

Day of week. Friday and Saturday carry a 15-30% uplift over the base in most markets. Three-night minimums on weekends lock in revenue.

Seasonality. Holiday weekends, school breaks, local events drive 50-200% uplifts. Build a season calendar before the year starts, then update as new events are confirmed.

Lead time. Last-minute (under 14 days) typically warrants a discount. Same-day can be 30% off. 60+ days out is typically worth slight premium pricing.

Occupancy. Calendar empty 30 days out? Lower price 5-10% across the gap. 80% booked 30 days out? Raise the gap 5%.

The pricing software decision

PriceLabs, Wheelhouse, Beyond Pricing — all automate the day-to-day. If you are managing 3+ properties, one of these pays for itself within the first month. For 1-2 properties, the cost-benefit is closer to break-even — manual daily pricing is fine if you have the discipline.

Either way, you still review the recommended price once a week and override when you know something the algorithm doesn't.

The minimum-night, maximum-night rules

Your minimum-night setting is also a pricing lever. A 2-night minimum captures weekend-only stays that a 3-night would lose. A 4-night minimum pushes mid-week bookings off.

Default for most urban and cabin properties: 2-night minimum on weekdays, 3-night minimum on weekends. Lifted to 4-7 nights around holidays when every night is bookable.

The cleaning fee decision

Cleaning fees should cover your actual turnover clean cost plus a small margin. Keep them visible — guests filter on cleaning fee as much as on nightly rate. A \$200 cleaning fee on a \$150/night property is a deal-breaker; the same fee on a \$400/night property is fine.

Module 07 — Done. Module 08 has the monthly statement.

The Monthly Statement: Keep Owners Renewing

The single biggest reason cohost engagements end: the owner didn't feel in control. The monthly statement fixes that. Done well, it is the document that makes the owner say, 'I am glad I hired them' every single month.

What goes in the statement

- **Cover line.** 'Here is the [Month] statement for [Property]. Net payout to you: \$[X]. [One sentence about what happened.]'
- **Revenue breakdown.** Gross bookings, platform fees, net to host. By booking if there were multiple.
- **Expenses pass-through.** Cleaning (number of turns), supplies, maintenance calls, vendor payments. Each line item with vendor and amount.
- **Cohost fee.** The fee you earned under the contract. Visible. Never buried.
- **Net payout.** The line the owner cares about. Bold, large, at the bottom.
- **This month vs last month.** Revenue, occupancy, average nightly rate. Side by side. Optional YoY.
- **Coming up.** Anything they should know about next month: local event, planned maintenance window, refinance or sale.
- **Open actions.** Anything the owner needs to do: approve vendor invoice, sign renewal, confirm a booking.

When to send it

By the 5th of the following month, every month. If you cannot hit the 5th, communicate early. Silence until the 8th is the second biggest reason owners leave.

If the property had zero bookings in the month, send the statement anyway. An empty statement that arrives on time is more reassuring than silence.

The quarterly review

Every quarter, schedule a 30-minute call to walk the owner through the trailing three months.

- Trend in revenue, occupancy, ADR vs market comps
- Maintenance issues — any structural (capital expense the owner should know about)
- Pricing experiments from the quarter: what we tried, what worked
- Operational SOPs updated this quarter and why
- Forward-looking opportunities (additional nights, new platforms, off-season marketing)

Module 08 — Done. Module 09 has the owner-outreach scripts.

MODULE 09

Owner Outreach: 5 Email Scripts + 4 Channels

The most expensive activity for a new cohost is finding the first 5 owners to manage for. Once you have 5, referrals do most of the work. Until you have 5, you are doing sales. This module covers the three outreach channels that have worked, in priority order.

Channel 1: Airbnb / VRBO listing-mining

Identify 50-100 listings in your city that match your niche, have review scores below 4.7, and have stale calendars. Send a polite low-friction first email. Reference a specific thing you noticed about the listing.

Channel 2: Local real-estate networks

Real estate agents, property managers, and HOA managers see owner-overwhelmed situations every week. They are not your competitors; they are your distribution channel. Build a one-pager they can hand to a frustrated owner.

Channel 3: Furnished Finder + remote-owner circles

If you serve mid-term (30+ night) market, Furnished Finder is the primary surface. Active posts, DMs, strong profile compound over time.

Channel 4: Reddit value-add comments

Find posts asking 'how do I start cohosting' / 'should I become a cohost' / 'what to charge'. Reply with 2-3 sentences of value, then 'I have a free resource on this if you want — DM me'.

The 5 email scripts

1. Cold pitch (listing-mining):

Subject: Quick observation about [Property Name] Hi [owner name], I'm [your name], a cohost in [city]. I came across your listing at [address] while reviewing the [cabin / urban / etc.] market. I noticed two patterns that often cost owners in your market \$X/year: 1. [Specific observation – calendar stale, photo count low, etc.] 2. [Second specific observation] I'm offering a free 15-minute audit – no pitch, no contract, just observations on what's fixable. If you're interested, reply with a time that works and I'll send a calendar link.

2. Follow-up after no reply (7 days):

Following up on the audit offer I sent last week. If you weren't interested or the timing is off, no problem – happy to take you off the list. If you are still curious but didn't get to it, I can do the audit async (just the link to your listing) and send you the observations in writing – no calendar needed. Reply 'send it' if that works.

3. Discovery call opener (first 5 minutes):

Open with: (1) thank-you for the time, (2) one specific thing I noticed about the listing, (3) the two questions I want to answer: 'what's working for you right now?' and 'what's not?' Don't pitch in the first 5 minutes. Tone: curious, not selling.

4. Audit delivery message:

Email 48 hours after the discovery call. Audit is attached. Cover: (1) what I looked at, (2) top 3 fixes for week 1, (3) top 3 fixes for month 1, (4) my proposed engagement model + fee, (5) when I'd like to follow up. The audit does the selling.

5. Monthly statement cover (see Module 8):

The follow-up cadence

If no reply: one follow-up at 7 days, then stop. Persistent follow-ups flag you as spam.

Module 09 — Done. Module 10 has the scaling framework.

MODULE 10

Scaling: 1 to 5 Properties, the Time-Per-Property Milestones

The first 3 properties teach you the work. Properties 4-9 teach you the systems. Properties 10-15 teach you the business. This module covers the inflection points and what changes at each one.

Properties 1-3: Do the work yourself

You are doing every message, every pricing update, every cleaning coordination yourself. Build your SOPs in real time, document them in Notion or a shared doc.

Time per property: 18-25 hours/week. Don't take a fourth property until your time per property is consistently below 12 hours/week.

Properties 4-9: Systematize

Hire your first cleaner. Build a cleaning checklist and a turnover workflow. Hire your first part-time helper or VA for guest communications. Document everything they need to read.

Time per property with one helper: 8-12 hours/week.

Properties 10-15: Hire and delegate

Hire a second cleaner or a small cleaning team. Hire your first full-time assistant (operations coordinator). Train them on every SOP you have written. Their job is to run the SOPs, not to make decisions — decisions stay with you.

At 15 properties, you are probably ready to hire a managing cohost (someone with a track record who can own 5-7 properties end-to-end under your brand). Your role shifts: account management, owner relationships, business development, pricing strategy.

Time per property with a coordinator + a managing cohost: 3-5 hours/week.

The mistake that kills most cohosting practices

Scaling too fast. Taking properties 5 and 6 before you have actually systematized properties 3 and 4. Service quality collapses. Renewal rates drop. Referrals dry up. You burn out within 12-18 months and shut it down.

The discipline is: only take a new property when your existing portfolio is running at the time target for that scale. Fix the systems first.

What comes after 15 properties

Two paths. You become a cohosting agency (a real entity with a brand, multiple operators, a sales pipeline, 30-100 properties). Or you stay as a high-touch solo operator with 12-15 properties at premium pricing. Both are real businesses. Most cohosts who hit 15 chose one within 90 days.

The HostFlow STR Starter System ends here.

If you made it through all 10 modules, you have the operating reference for a real cohosting practice: the operating definition, 30-day plan, pricing, contract, audit, screening, dynamic pricing, monthly statements, owner outreach, and the scaling path.

For the 6-week mentorship cohort + live feedback, see the \$1,000 option at hostflow.me/mentorship.